

Gastroenterology Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS
OPERATIONS POLICY HANDBOOK

SERVICE LINE: GASTROENTEROLOGY

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1.0 PURPOSE

1.1 This document outlines the operational policies for the Gastroenterology service line at Meridian Health Partners, ensuring consistent service delivery across all 14 clinic sites and clarity for clinical and administrative staff.

1.2 This handbook defines the scope of accepted conditions, patient management protocols, insurance plan coverage specific to gastroenterology, and internal referral processing commitments.

2.0 SCOPE OF SERVICE

2.1 Conditions Accepted for Consultation and Outpatient Management:

2.1.1 Gastroesophageal Reflux Disease (GERD)

2.1.2 Irritable Bowel Syndrome (IBS)

2.1.3 Inflammatory Bowel Disease (Crohn's Disease, Ulcerative Colitis)

2.1.4 Celiac Disease and other malabsorption syndromes

2.1.5 Diverticular Disease

2.1.6 Peptic Ulcer Disease

2.1.7 Chronic Constipation and Chronic Diarrhea

2.1.8 Dysphagia (non-acute)

2.1.9 Hepatitis C Management (initial evaluation and outpatient antiviral therapy coordination)

2.1.10 Screening Colonoscopy referrals for patients aged 45 and above.

2.2 Conditions Explicitly Not Accepted for Direct Referral or Management:

2.2.1 Acute gastrointestinal hemorrhage requiring immediate inpatient stabilization.

2.2.2 Bowel obstruction (complete or partial) requiring emergent surgical intervention.

2.2.3 Acute pancreatitis or cholecystitis requiring inpatient admission.

2.2.4 Esophageal foreign body impaction (refer to Emergency Department or Surgical Services).

2.2.5 Unstable patients presenting with acute abdominal pain of undetermined etiology requiring immediate diagnostic imaging and potential surgical consultation.

2.2.6 Patients requiring liver transplant evaluation or management beyond initial screening (refer to specialized transplant centers, e.g., St. Jude Medical Center Liver Institute).

3.0 PATIENT APPOINTMENT MANAGEMENT

3.1 Typical Appointment Duration:

3.1.1 New Patient Consultations: Scheduled for 45 minutes.

3.1.2 Follow-up Consultations: Scheduled for 20 minutes.

3.1.3 Endoscopy/Colonoscopy Pre-Procedure Consultations: Scheduled for 15 minutes.

3.2 Patient Preparation Instructions (General Guidelines):

3.2.1 Upper Endoscopy (EGD): Patients are instructed to fast for a minimum of 8 hours prior to the procedure, including no food or liquids.

3.2.2 Colonoscopy: Patients receive detailed instructions specific to the prescribed bowel preparation agent. General instructions include a clear liquid diet for the 24 hours preceding the procedure, commencing at 12:00 PM on the day prior to the scheduled procedure. No solid food is permitted after this time.

3.2.3 Capsule Endoscopy: Patients are instructed to fast for 12 hours prior to arrival for the procedure.

3.2.4 All pre-procedure instructions are provided in writing via the MyMeridian Patient Portal and confirmed verbally by the scheduling coordinator 3 business days prior to the appointment.

4.0 INSURANCE COVERAGE FOR GASTROENTEROLOGY PROCEDURES (MERIDIAN HEALTH PLANS)

4.1 This section details coverage for key gastroenterological procedures under Meridian Health's

proprietary insurance plans. All plans require prior authorization for specific procedures as noted.

4.2 Meridian Core Plan:

4.2.1 Covers EGD (Esophagogastroduodenoscopy) for diagnostic purposes for patients aged 18 and older. Prior authorization is required.

4.2.2 Covers initial consultation for GERD and IBS management.

4.2.3 Does not cover screening colonoscopies; diagnostic colonoscopies are covered with a 25% co-insurance after deductible.

4.3 Meridian Plus Plan:

4.3.1 Covers EGD and Colonoscopy (diagnostic and screening for patients aged 45+) with a \$50 copay per procedure. Prior authorization is required for diagnostic procedures.

4.3.2 Covers initial and follow-up consultations for all accepted conditions.

4.3.3 Does not cover Capsule Endoscopy.

4.4 Meridian Premium Plan:

4.4.1 Covers EGD, Colonoscopy (diagnostic and screening), and Flexible Sigmoidoscopy with no copay. Prior authorization is required only for therapeutic EGD.

4.4.2 Covers Capsule Endoscopy once every 5 years for diagnostic purposes with prior authorization.

4.4.3 Covers outpatient management of Hepatitis C, including antiviral prescriptions.

4.5 Meridian Elite Plan:

4.5.1 Covers all gastroenterological procedures offered at Meridian Health Partners facilities, including EGD, Colonoscopy (diagnostic and screening), Flexible Sigmoidoscopy, and Capsule Endoscopy, with no copay or deductible.

4.5.2 Covers 1 annual Capsule Endoscopy for surveillance or diagnostic purposes, subject to medical necessity and prior authorization.

4.5.3 Covers all outpatient consultations and procedures related to accepted conditions.

5.0 REFERRAL MANAGEMENT

5.1 The Gastroenterology department commits to processing all incoming referrals within 2 business days of receipt.

5.2 Urgent referrals, as designated by the referring physician and marked "URGENT" in the electronic referral system (MeridianConnect), will be reviewed by a specialist within 4 business hours of receipt.

5.3 Patients will be contacted for scheduling within 3 business days of referral processing for non-urgent cases.

6.0 POLICY REVIEW

6.1 This policy is subject to annual review by the Gastroenterology Department Head, Dr. Evelyn Reed, and the Chief Operations Officer, Mr. Arthur Vance, or more frequently as operational needs or regulatory changes dictate.